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Language, Conceptualization and Awakening: on the Paradox of Discourse in Classical Indian Yogacara

John Y Cha

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 John Y. Cha
 Gustavus Adolphus College

1. Proem

The following essay attempts to do two things: it seeks to analyze Indian Buddhist (*Yogacara*) understandings of the relation between language (doctrine) and reality (Suchness), and relate this analysis to contemporary issues. This is a tall order, one perhaps a bit too tall for a single paper. Hence, the second part is unavoidably (too) brief: the only issue broached is the difficulty and importance of comparative analysis between the proverbial “East” and “West”. On the other hand, the first attempt is carried out through an analysis of *Yogacara* philosophy and its embeddedness in classical Indian intellectual culture (approximately 500 BCE to 500 CE). However, one consequence of the heightened state of specialization (endemic not only to academia but also to most “technologized” cultures) is that discourse is becoming increasingly narrowed; therefore, my analysis is unavoidably focused on one school of Buddhist thought whose texts were composed between the fourth and sixth centuries of the Common Era. Therefore, a large portion of this essay is of necessity technical, in some cases more suited for those who specialize in Buddhist Studies. But all is not lost, despite the extremes of generality and specialization herein. For we find in the intellectual culture of classical India an extreme form of privileging theory over practice, a conscious effort throughout the period to construct what we would call nowadays a metanarrative. And, on the basis of a close reading of their texts I conclude that *Yogacara* thinkers ‘occasioned’ modes of thought that would have seemed to subvert, if only potentially or ideally, the strict hierarchy of theory over practice. Now, it is *not* my contention that *Yogacara* thinkers consciously engaged in a type of deconstruction. However, if some layers of ‘subversive occasioning’ lie in texts whose times, places and situations are far removed from our own, then that is in itself good enough reason to begin digging.

2. Introduction

3. The Shastric Context of Buddhist Discourse

Cultural knowledge is transcendent in origin, and its authority is therefore unimpeachable. Since this knowledge is always already revealed to human beings via *sastra* their mastery of the practices inscribed therein is a function of conformity to the preexistent paradigm. Thus the process of amelioration conceived of as “progress” in the post-Enlightenment West is here instead “regression” to the normative divine model; what is there viewed as “discovery” is here in essence nothing but recovery.¹

¹In this paper I will discuss this metaphysical derivation (from reality to language) and signification (from language to reality) found in the (textually inscribed) discourse of classical Indian *Yogacara*. I will begin with an (all too brief) analysis of the embeddedness of *Yogacara* doctrine in the intellectual culture of classical India, focusing on the literary genre of *sastra*. Next, I analyze the contents (philosophical strategies) of select *Yogacara* texts—specifically those concerned with ontology and epistemology. It is here that we will detect *reversals* of some fundamental notions found in classical Indian/Buddhist theory. It is these reversals, I will argue, that disclose 1) an “ontological paradox”, namely, that *absence discloses presence*, and 2) a *linguistically dependent* ontology. I will conclude this paper with some general remarks about the relevance of our analysis of the above ontological paradox/dependency to contemporary postmodern issues. What I want to suggest in a preliminary way is that the implicit *an-archic*[^2] themes found in *Yogacara* thought have their parallels with some issues in postmodern discourse.

4.0. Yogacara: Text/Ontology

4.1. Reversals: Immanence/Transcendence

4.2. Being/Non-Being

Non-being [means] that this verbal designation of “form” up to the verbal designation of “nirvana” is without an objective basis, that is, it is without characterization, that the basis of verbal designation is completely non-existent, that is, completely absent. Verbal designation functions without relying on any existing thing. This is called non-being.²

And also, whosoever negates the locus for the characteristic of verbal designation, which is the basis for the characteristic of verbal designation, completely negates the object that is the ineffable, ultimately real existence. [Thus the nihilist states]: “everything is completely non-existent.”³

Anything posited as the self-nature (*svabhava*) of verbal designation (*prajñaptivada*)’ [Indeed], the self-nature of the factors of existence (*dharma*) is the “referent” of verbal designation, and it is called “being” by the worldly.[¹⁴]

And whosoever attaches to the own-nature of the verbal designation for factors of existence, i.e., the specific characteristic of form, etc., [does so] because of the postulation of existence upon that which does not exist.⁴

Unreal mental construction exists; in that [unreal mental construction] duality does not exist (1ab).

But here [in unreal mental construction] emptiness exists; that [unreal mental construction] too exists in that [emptiness] (1cd).⁵

²The clarification of the cultural context of Indian Buddhist discourse, namely the primacy of theory (*sastra*) over practice (*prayoga*) sheds light on some general aspects of the relation between language and awakening in *Yogacara* thought. However, a closer look at *Yogacara* philosophical discourse reveals some paradoxes in the language/reality relation. Specifically, the concepts of transcendence and immanence as they pertain to ontological and epistemological notions in the texts under consideration *reverse* commonly held ideas both in the pan-Indian intellectual context as well as Western thought in general. Moreover, the discursive strategies employed in the *Yogacara* texts’ specifically, “navigating” the middle path’ disclose another paradox in the relation between language and Suchness; namely, a kind of linguistically, or textually, dependent ontology. The aspects of *discursive mediation* and *embodied locus* discussed above provide a conceptual space for clarifying specific *Yogacara* interpretations of the pan-Indian understanding of the language/reality relation.

³The philosophical content of the texts under consideration involves questions concerning the ontological and epistemological relations between linguistic/conceptual constructions and their non- or pre-constructed foundation. Contrary to some previous analyses of the *Yogacara* notion of reality, this analysis does *not* entail the mere clarification of some metaphysical source for these illusion-enhancing activities.[⁸] Rather, it proceeds with an investigation of the intersection, or more accurately, the ‘mutual inherency’ of the epistemological and ontological realms and takes into account both the general strategy of philosophizing employed by *Yogacara* intellectuals and the resulting ontological paradox of their thought; namely, that *absence discloses presence*. What this paradox entails will unfold throughout my investigation. Here I begin with a (brief) discussion of epistemology’ in this context defined primarily in terms of illusion construction’ and ontology’ defined in foundational terms with respect to language and conceptualization.

⁴Issues concerning ontology and epistemology in the *Yogacara* context revolve around the question of the ontological status of both consciousness (*vijnana*) and the objects of consciousness (*vijñeya*). *Yogacara* intellectuals describe three possible answers to the question, “what, if anything, exists?” 1) the objects of consciousness, like consciousness itself, exist as independent realities; 2) consciousness and the objects of consciousness are merely conventional designations and therefore are non-existent; 3) the objects of consciousness do not exist, but consciousness does. Of these three possibilities, the *Yogacara* argue for the third, that consciousness is the sole existence.[⁹] Before discussing the specific *Yogacara* arguments for this view a brief discussion of the epistemological and ontological spheres is in order.

⁵*Abhutaparikalā sti dvayam. tatra na vidyate/*

Some maintain that all factors of existence are completely without self-nature, just like the horns of a rabbit. For that reason, in order to counter the negation of all things (*sarvopavada*) [Maitreya] said,

Unreal mental construction exists (1a);

“in-itself” (*svabhavatas*) should be added. [The opponent objects:] Is it not the case that this assertion contradicts scripture, because it is said in scripture that “all factors of existence are empty”? [We respond:] There is no contradiction because [it is further stated that]

in that [unreal mental construction] duality does not exist. (1b)

Indeed, unreal mental construction which is devoid of the [duality] of any entity of subject and object of cognition, is called “empty” but not completely without self-nature.⁶

Or, in order to counter the view, “visual form, etc., exist as real entities apart from mind and mental functions”, [Maitreya] stated

Unreal mental construction exists (1a);

“as a real entity” [should be added]. Visual form does not exist separated from that [consciousness]. Why? Since,

in that [unreal mental construction] duality does not exist (1b)

Indeed, unreal mental construction is neither the perceiver of something nor is it perceived by anything. However, [unreal mental construction] as the absence of the subject and object of perception is the sole reality (*bhavamatra*).⁷

4.3. The Presence of Absence

But here [in unreal mental construction] emptiness exists; that [unreal mental construction] too exists in that [emptiness].

4.4. Primacy of the Text and Ontological Dependency

[A designation] is neither the essential nature of that *dharma*, nor is it wholly other than that. That [essential nature] is neither the sphere of speech nor the object of speech; nor is it altogether different from these. That being the case, the essential nature of *dharmanas* is not found in the way in which it is expressed. But further, neither is absolutely nothing found. Again, the essential nature is absent and yet not absolutely absent.[^23]

And also, whosoever negates the locus for the characteristic of verbal designation, which is the basis for the characteristic of verbal designation, completely negates the object that is the ineffable, ultimately real existence.⁸

5. Conclusion

⁶ke cid virundhanti sarvadharmah sarvatha nihsvabhavah sasavisanaavad ity atah sarvopavada pratisedhartham aha

⁷atha va cittacaittebhyo nyatra rupadaya dravyatvena santiti yesam darsanam tatpratisedhartham aha

⁸The erroneous view of “being”, on the other hand, is one of postulating a mode of existence upon phenomena that are in actuality non-existent. It is a naïve realism that admits of the ontological existence of linguistic referents; in other words, designations such as “visible objects” correspond to actually existing objects. Again citing from the *Bodhisattvabhumi* Asanga defines “being” as:

Notes

*abhutaparikalpo sti [iti] svabhavata iti vakyasesah / nanv evam. su4travirodhah sarvadharmah sunya iti sutre vacanat / nasti virodhah yasmad dvayam. tatra na vidyate / abhutaparikalpo sti [iti sa evasti] dravyatah / nasti rupam. tadvyatiriktam. [nasti] dravyata iti / kim. karanam yasmad dvayam tatra na vidyate * * **

John Y. Cha (Ph D Northwestern University), is an Assistant Professor of Religion at Gustavus Adolphus College in Minnesota. He specializes in classical Indian Buddhist philosophy focusing on the Yogacara and Madhyamika schools. His other interests include modern Japanese philosophy (Kyoto School), comparative philosophy and phenomenology.

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